

Friday, 16 January 2026

Severe Flooding Leaves Wales Village Cut Off



Residents of Wales Village in Ward 32, Bushbuckridge, have been left completely cut off from essential services.

Residents of Wales Village in Ward 32, Bushbuckridge, have been left completely cut off from essential services after heavy rains caused the area's only access route to flood, raising serious safety and humanitarian concerns.

According to community members, the flooding has submerged a low-lying bridge that serves as the sole entry and exit point to the village. Residents say the situation is unprecedented, with water levels

higher than those experienced during the severe floods of 2000.

Although an assessment was previously conducted for the construction of a proper bridge, the process never progressed beyond that stage. In addition, residents were promised a tarred ring road during the 2019 election period, but no development has since taken place.

As a result, the community is now isolated. In the event of a medical

emergency, residents are unable to reach a clinic, hospital or mortuary. Community leaders warn that this lack of access places lives at immediate risk, as even minor illnesses or accidents could turn fatal due to delays in receiving help.

The flooding also poses a serious danger to learners who must cross the affected route to attend school. With persistent rainfall, many children may be unable to travel safely, potentially disrupting their

education and exposing them to further risk.

Calls have been made for urgent intervention by the Department of Public Works, Roads and Transport to implement immediate temporary measures to restore safe access.

Residents are also demanding that long-term solutions, including the construction of a proper bridge and the promised tarred road, be prioritised without further delay.

Community members say reliable infrastructure is essential, not optional, and that no village should be left stranded whenever it rains. They are urging authorities to act swiftly to ensure safety, dignity and uninterrupted access to vital services for the people of Wales Village in Bushbuckridge.



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SPIRITUAL REBIRTH

A Fresh Start Through Christ

"Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: the old has gone, the new is here!" — 2 Corinthians 5:17 (NIVUK)

This verse is a powerful reminder of the transformative nature of faith. It declares that anyone who belongs to Christ is no longer defined by their past. Mistakes, failures, and former identities no longer hold power over those who have found life in Him. Instead, they are made new — spiritually reborn with fresh purpose, value, and direction.

Many people carry guilt, regret, or a deep longing to start over. This scripture offers hope: true change is possible. Not a surface-level makeover, but a complete inner renewal. It assures believers that their past no longer has the final word;

God does. This new beginning doesn't mean immediate perfection, but a process of transformation. The Holy Spirit works within to renew hearts, shape character, and realign one's life to God's will.

As we enter new seasons — whether a new year, relationship, career, or chapter of life — this verse invites us to embrace the fresh start God offers. In Christ, we are not who we used to be. We are being made into something new, something beautiful, one day at a time.

Mpumalanga Celebrates Strong Matric Results



Mpumalanga's top achiever Luyanda Ndlozi.
Mpumalanga has once again demonstrated its commitment to education after achieving an impressive 86.55% pass rate in the 2025 National Senior Certificate (NSC) examinations.

Premier Mandla Ndlovu announced the results with pride, noting that the province improved on its 84.9% pass rate recorded in 2024. Mpumalanga's performance also contributed to South Africa's historic national matric pass rate of 88%.

A standout success story from the province is Luyanda Ndlozi from Elangwana Secondary School, who emerged as Mpumalanga's top achiever and ranked among the top 40 learners nationally.

His achievement highlights the potential of learners in the province when given the necessary support and opportunities.

Reflecting on the journey of the Class of 2025, Premier Ndlovu acknowledged the unique challenges they faced. "The Class of 2025 started high school during the COVID-19 pandemic, yet their commitment prevailed. Behind every success story stands a dedicated teacher, a parent who sacrificed, and a community that believed," he said.

In recognition of excellence and to further support education, the Mandla Ndlovu Foundation, in partnership with the Department of Education, donated full school uniforms to 1,000 learners across 10 top-performing schools that achieved a 100% pass rate.

Premier Ndlovu emphasised that education remains central to the province's development.

"We see each successful matriculation as a step towards building a prosperous future—an era where education becomes the foundation for economic empowerment and social progress," he said.

The province extended its congratulations to the Class of 2025, encouraging learners to carry their success forward and continue making Mpumalanga proud.



CRIME

Illegal Immigrants, Traffickers Arrested



The South African Police Service (SAPS) in Mpumalanga has arrested twelve suspects during a crime prevention operation conducted in the Bushbuckridge policing area over the weekend.

The operation, carried out under Operation Safer Festive Season by the former Acornhoek Cluster Crime Prevention Team, took place from 4pm on Friday, 10 January, until 4am on Saturday, 11 January 2026. It focused on preventing crime and disrupting serious and organised criminal activities.

The arrests were made during stop-and-search operations along the R40 road in the Dwarsloop area. Police stopped and searched a taxi with Mozambican registration, leading to the apprehension of the suspects.

Ten of the suspects were arrested for contravening South Africa's Immigration Act and are believed to be undocumented foreign nationals from Mozambique. The remaining two suspects were arrested on charges related to human trafficking.

Police also carried out extensive crime prevention activities across the wider Bushbuckridge area as part of the operation.

Detectives are working closely with the Department of Home Affairs to verify the legal status of the arrested individuals. All twelve suspects are expected to appear before the Bushbuckridge Magistrate's Court soon.

Mass Arrests and Seizures in Mpumalanga

A major law enforcement initiative, Operation Shanela II, has led to numerous arrests, seizures, and inspections across Mpumalanga. The operation, which ran from 8 to 11 January, involved the South African Police Service (SAPS), Traffic Police, law enforcement agencies, and several government departments, including Home Affairs, Health, and Correctional Services, alongside private security and community policing forums.

During the operation, authorities conducted:

- 72 premises searches and visits

- 5 623 people and 1 789 vehicles screened

- 1 258 patrols and 546 stop-and-searches

- 101 vehicle checkpoints and 28 roadblocks

- 3 240 patrols across the province

- Tracing of 111 wanted suspects

- Searches of 17 hostels

Businesses and commercial operations were also inspected, with nine unlicensed liquor outlets closed, 240 licensed liquor outlets checked, 45 second-hand dealers inspected, and 578 informal businesses, including spaza shops, scrutinised for labour-law compliance. Additionally, 160 farms and 23 mines were visited.

The operation resulted in arrests for a wide range of crimes, including:



- 224 for assault with grievous bodily harm

- 256 for driving under the influence

- 186 for illegal liquor dealing

- 51 for drug possession and 17 for drug dealing

- 12 for murder and 28 for rape

- 108 illegal immigrants detained

Significant items were confiscated during the operation, including 55 kg of dagga,

cocaine, heroin, crystal meth, 166.7 litres of alcohol, 65.7 kg of precious metals, 3 028 counterfeit items, cash amounting to R45 400, and several vehicles and firearms.

Acting Provincial Commissioner Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi praised officers and stakeholders for their “dedication and professionalism,” while also thanking law-abiding community members for their support.

“Together, we will continue to intensify our efforts to create a safer and more secure Mpumalanga for all,” he said

33 Undocumented Children Intercepted at Beitbridge



The Border Management Authority (BMA) has intercepted another group of undocumented minor children at the Beitbridge Port of Entry on Tuesday, 13 January 2026.

According to the BMA, the interception took place at around 12:30 when a junior

border guard, deployed during the relief shift, stopped and searched a Zimbabwe-registered minibus taxi at the port of entry. The vehicle was found to be transporting 33 undocumented children, aged between four and 15, who were travelling from South Africa to Zimbabwe.

Two Zimbabwean men, aged 32 and 23, were arrested on suspicion of facilitating the illegal cross-border movement of the children. Criminal cases have been opened against the suspects under the Immigration Act for the facilitation of the illegal entry and movement of undocumented persons. They are expected to appear in court later this week.

All 33 children were immediately handed over to the Department of Social Development for further processing, in accordance with child protection protocols and South Africa’s domestic and international obligations to safeguard vulnerable persons.

The Commissioner of the Border Management Authority, Dr Michael

Masiapato, praised the junior border guard for his vigilance and professionalism, saying the interception demonstrated the effectiveness of strengthened border controls. He also urged parents and guardians to refrain from sending undocumented children through ports of entry.

“The Border Management Authority will not tolerate the exploitation of children or the facilitation of illegal cross-border movement. We remain committed to protecting the integrity of our borders while upholding human rights and child protection principles,” said Dr Masiapato.

Investigations into the matter are continuing.

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Real Pass Rate Raises Alarm

ActionSA has raised serious concerns about South Africa’s matric results, arguing that the widely celebrated 88% pass rate masks deep and ongoing failures within the basic education system.

In a statement issued on 12 January 2026, ActionSA Parliamentary Chief Whip Lerato Ngobeni MP congratulated the Class of 2025 for completing their National Senior Certificate under challenging conditions, and acknowledged the role played by teachers and families. She said every learner who perseveres to the end of matric deserves recognition.

However, ActionSA cautioned that headline pass rates do not present a full or honest

picture of the system’s performance. Using a cohort-based analysis, which tracks how many learners who entered Grade 10 in 2023 eventually passed matric, the party calculates the effective pass rate at just 57.7%.

This figure is based on the 1.14 million learners who began Grade 10, nearly half of whom did not successfully complete matric.

According to ActionSA, this gap reflects a schooling system that continues to lose learners through dropout, repetition and disengagement long before they reach their final examinations. The party argues that success is being defined by reducing the number of learners who write matric, rather

than by improving learning outcomes across the board.

The party also highlighted ongoing safety and infrastructure challenges in schools. Ngobeni pointed to the recent death of a six-year-old girl in Nkuzana village, Limpopo, who fell into a pit toilet, despite such facilities being banned since 2013. A parliamentary reply last year revealed that about 590 schools across the country still rely on pit toilets, more than a decade after government committed to eradicating them.

“A system that cannot guarantee basic safety and dignity for learners cannot credibly claim success based on pass percentages alone,” Ngobeni said.

ActionSA reiterated its call for comprehensive education reform, including honest reporting of matric outcomes against full learner cohorts, the abolition of the 30% pass mark in favour of meaningful minimum standards, and structured academic support for learners who fall behind.

The party also supports the reintroduction of Annual National Assessments and transparent school-level performance data to rebuild accountability.

Looking ahead, ActionSA argues that South Africa needs an education system aligned with the realities of a modern economy. It has proposed a dual-stream education model from Grade 10, allowing learners to choose between academic and vocational pathways that respond to the country’s skills needs.

“Our education system is not failing by accident,” Ngobeni said. “It is failing because leaders repeatedly choose political comfort over honest reform.” ActionSA says it will continue to push for higher standards, safer schools and an education system that prepares young South Africans not only to pass, but to thrive.

Popular Panorama Route Sites Closed



The Mpumalanga Tourism and Parks Agency (MTPA) has announced the temporary closure of several popular attractions along the Panorama Route due to persistent heavy rainfall in the province.

In a statement issued on Tuesday, the agency confirmed that God’s Window, The Pinnacle and Bourke’s Luck Potholes have been closed to both tourists and members of the public.

According to MTPA, the decision follows further safety assessments conducted in response to ongoing heavy rains, which have increased the risk of slippery surfaces, rockfalls and other hazardous conditions at these sites. The closures are aimed at prioritising the safety of visitors as well as agency employees.

“MTPA appeals to tourists and the business community to exercise patience and understanding during this period,” the agency said.

Visitors are encouraged to explore alternative attractions across Mpumalanga, also known as the Place of the Rising Sun, while conditions stabilise.

The Panorama Route is one of Mpumalanga’s most visited tourism corridors, attracting both local and international travellers.

MTPA has assured the public that the situation is being closely monitored and that further communication will be issued once weather conditions improve and the affected sites are deemed safe for access.

Recalled Infant Formula Raises Safety Concerns



Parents and caregivers have been urged to stop using a specific infant formula following a national product recall linked to potential contamination that may pose a health risk to babies.

The affected product is Nestlé NAN Special Pro HA Infant Formula (0–12 months), sold in an 800g can, with batch number 51660742F3 and a best-before date of 15 December 2026. The formula, which has been available on the South African market since September 2025, is intended for the dietary management of infants with allergies

to cow’s milk. The recall follows the identification of a possible presence of cereulide, a toxin produced by the bacterium *Bacillus cereus*. Cereulide is considered a food safety concern and, if consumed, may cause symptoms such as severe or persistent vomiting, diarrhoea, or unusual lethargy, particularly in young infants. Health authorities have confirmed that the contamination has been traced back to a manufacturing facility in Germany that

supplies several countries, including South Africa. Importantly, South Africa is reported to have received only this specific batch, and no other Nestlé products or batch numbers are affected by the recall.

While no illnesses linked to the affected product have been confirmed locally, parents and caregivers are urged to remain vigilant. They are advised to monitor infants for any concerning symptoms and to consult a healthcare provider immediately if there are worries about a child’s health, even if symptoms are mild or absent.

Consumers are encouraged to carefully check the batch number and best-before date on the product packaging. Anyone who has the recalled formula in their possession should return it to the place of purchase for a full refund.

Authorities have emphasised that there is no need for panic, noting that precautionary measures are being taken in line with strict food safety and quality protocols. Ongoing engagement with relevant stakeholders is underway to ensure the protection of infant health.

The recall has also renewed calls to support and promote breastfeeding as the optimal method of infant feeding. Exclusive breastfeeding is recommended for the first six months of life, with continued breastfeeding up to two years or beyond alongside the gradual introduction of solid foods.

Parents, caregivers and the public will continue to be informed of any developments related to the recall as more information becomes available.

Heavy Rains Leave Potholes Temporarily Closed



Bourke’s Luck Potholes have been temporarily closed to the public following heavy rainfall in the area, the Mpumalanga Tourism and Parks Agency (MTPA) announced on Monday.

The popular tourist attraction, located along the Panorama Route, has been shut as a safety precaution to protect visitors and employees amid hazardous conditions caused by the recent downpours.

MTPA acknowledged that the closure may inconvenience tourists and negatively affect local businesses that rely on visitor traffic. However, the agency emphasised that the decision was taken in the interest of public safety.

Members of the public and tourists have been urged to avoid accessing Bourke’s Luck Potholes until further notice, as conditions remain unsafe.

The agency has appealed to tourists and the business community to exercise patience and understanding during this period. Visitors are encouraged to explore alternative attractions across Mpumalanga, commonly known as the “Place of the Rising Sun”, while the site remains closed.

MTPA said further communication will be issued once the situation improves and the area is deemed safe for reopening.

Residents Warned As Heavy Rains Persist



The Bushbuckridge Local Municipality has urged residents to remain highly vigilant following a level 9 weather warning issued due to persistent heavy rainfall in the area.

According to the municipality’s Disaster, Fire and Rescue Unit, the warning was issued by the South African Weather Service and signals potentially dangerous conditions that may pose risks to lives, infrastructure and mobility.

Parents and guardians have been reminded

to closely monitor children and ensure they do not play unsupervised or travel alone during this period. With schools reopening, and some already operational, special caution has been advised for learners who walk to school. Parents are encouraged to accompany children, particularly those who must cross footbridges or low-lying bridges, and to only cross when conditions are safe.

Motorists have also been urged to exercise extreme caution on the roads. The municipality has warned drivers never to

attempt crossing flooded bridges, regardless of how shallow the water may appear. Road users are advised to switch on fog and rain lights, reduce speed and remain alert due to wet, slippery surfaces and the deteriorating condition of some roads.

Residents living near riverbanks and in low-lying areas have been advised to remain on high alert as rainfall continues. Should rivers burst their banks, community members are urged to move immediately to higher ground to avoid potential flooding.

The municipality has appealed for cooperation and responsible behaviour from the public to minimise the risk of injury, loss of life and damage to property during this period of severe weather.

In the event of an emergency, residents are urged to contact the Municipal Call Centre on 0800 014 751 or 013 065 0827. Alternatively, the Disaster Management, Fire and Rescue Manager, Mr R Silinda, can be reached on 060 506 4020 or 079 887 9814.

Dagga Plantation Worth Millions Uncovered



The operation, which was initiated ahead of the festive period, is led by the Mpumalanga Acting Provincial Police Commissioner, Dr Zeph Mkhwanazi.

Law-enforcement agencies, working alongside local farmers, have uncovered a large dagga plantation on the banks of the Mhlambanyatsi River near the Buffelspruit farms outside Malalane in the Nkomazi area.

The discovery was made on Friday, 9 January, during the ongoing Operation Safer Festive Season. The operation, which was initiated ahead of the festive period, is led by the Mpumalanga Acting Provincial Police Commissioner, Dr Zeph Mkhwanazi, and brings together traffic officers, senior police officials, SARS and customs authorities.

According to Mpumalanga police spokesperson Donald Mdhuli, information

was received regarding suspected illegal drug activity in the area, prompting a coordinated response by law-enforcement agencies.

“Upon investigation, officers discovered a field of dagga plants with an estimated street value of approximately R2.9 million,” Mdhuli said.

He confirmed that an immediate investigation has been launched and a formal enquiry opened to identify and apprehend those responsible for the illegal operation.

The dagga plants were subsequently



uprooted and destroyed as part of the police intervention.

Mkhwanazi reiterated the commitment of the police and their partners to combat drug-related crimes across the province. “We are determined to eradicate illegal drug activities and to ensure the safety and wellbeing of our communities,” he said.

Authorities have welcomed the cooperation of local farmers, noting that community involvement remains critical in the fight against organised crime and illicit activities in rural and farming areas. Residents are encouraged to continue reporting suspicious activities to the police as operations continue beyond the festive season.

Two-Year-Old Drowns in White River Stream

Police in Mpumalanga have opened an inquest following the drowning of a two-year-old boy in White River on Tuesday, 13 January 2026.

The incident occurred in Msholozhi C, where the child, identified as Sibusiso Mnisi, lived with his family near a stream. According to the child’s mother, Ms Thapiseng Mnisi, the toddler had been asleep inside the house when she briefly left to cross the nearby stream. Unaware that the child had followed her outside,

she later discovered that he had attempted to cross the stream on his own.

It is alleged that the strong current swept the child away. Emergency services and other relevant stakeholders were called to the scene, where paramedics certified the toddler dead.

Police have confirmed that a case of inquest has been opened to establish the full circumstances surrounding the incident.

The Acting Provincial Commissioner of the South African Police Service in Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, conveyed his heartfelt condolences to the Mnisi family. He also urged community members to remain extremely cautious, especially during the current wet weather conditions, warning that overflowing streams, rivers and dams pose serious dangers.

Residents are advised to closely supervise young children and to avoid crossing flooded waterways during periods of heavy rainfall.



Pafuri, Giryondo Posts Closed by Floods

Two international border posts within the Kruger National Park have been temporarily closed following severe weather conditions affecting parts of Limpopo and Mpumalanga.

The Border Management Authority has confirmed the closure of the Pafuri and Giryondo border posts after continuous heavy rainfall across the park, which follows a Level 6 severe weather warning issued for the region. Visitors have been urged to revise their travel plans and comply with guidance from park officials.

Several rivers within the park are currently flowing at high speed, with water levels expected to rise further. These include the De Laporte, N’watshitsaka and Crocodile rivers. The Sabie River is also rising and is



expected to impact the Sand River, which may disrupt travel routes between Satara Rest Camp, Tshokwane Picnic Site, Lower Sabie Rest Camp and Skukuza Rest Camp.

Park management has cautioned that road closures may occur at short notice for safety reasons. Campers in affected areas will be relocated within camps, with those in caravans and motorhomes being moved closer to chalet zones. Visitors have also been advised not to remain in low-lying camping areas vulnerable to flooding.

Guests travelling to Skukuza Airport from north of Tshokwane have been advised to use Kruger Gate via Satara or Orpen Gate, or alternatively access the airport from outside the park via the R40. Travellers are urged to allow extra time to avoid missing

flights.

Rainfall recorded overnight ranged from 25 mm in Phalaborwa to as high as 90 mm in Pafuri, with Tshokwane, Shingwedzi, Mooiplaas and Houtboschrand also recording significant rainfall.

SANParks has strongly urged all visitors and staff to obey no-entry and road-closure signage, avoid flooded roads and low-lying bridges, and not to remove debris or barriers placed on roads.

The South African Weather Service continues to monitor conditions and will issue updates as the situation evolves. The safety of visitors, staff and surrounding communities remains the park’s highest priority.

CONGRATULATIONS

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Sunbake Tournament Scores Big for Community Development



The annual Sunbake Football Tournament has once again proven that sport can do more than entertain.

The annual Sunbake Football Tournament has once again proven that sport can do more than entertain—it can transform communities. By promoting positive youth engagement, the tournament keeps young people active during the festive season, helping to combat laziness, substance abuse, and crime.

Families, supporters, and local businesses came together, uniting around a shared purpose and celebrating the spirit of community. With the tournament extending into early January, organisers were able to recognise and support local talent, keeping communities engaged beyond the holiday period and into the new year. This longer schedule reinforces continuity, purpose, and a sense of belonging for participants and supporters alike.



A major highlight this year was the focus on women's football, encouraging young girls to participate and challenging longstanding stereotypes around the sport. The inclusion of scouts from East High Academy, focusing on U15 and U19 players, provided an incredible opportunity for young talent to showcase their skills. For many participants, this is a first step toward pursuing a football career, opening doors to further development and exposure.

Organisers hope to attract more scouts in future editions, further strengthening the tournament's role in nurturing talent and driving positive change in the community. By combining sport, mentorship, and opportunity, the Sunbake Tournament continues to be a platform for growth, hope, and inspiration.

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